

The AI Visibility Glossary: 26 Terms Business Owners Should Know

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AI search comes with a pile of new acronyms and borrowed SEO terms, and most explanations assume you already know half of them. Here are 26 definitions in plain English, grouped by what they help you do.

Quick Answer

AI visibility is how often, and how accurately, AI engines like ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google's AI Overviews mention or recommend your business. The core terms: GEO (Generative Engine Optimization) is making your business understood and cited by generative AI; AEO (Answer Engine Optimization) is structuring content so it can be extracted as a direct answer; an entity is a clearly identifiable real-world thing such as a business or person; structured data (schema markup) labels your content in a machine-readable format; and a citation is a source an AI engine references when it answers. This glossary defines 26 terms in total, grouped by topic.

How to use this glossary

Each term below is defined in a sentence or two, grouped by what it helps you do. Skim for the term you keep seeing, or read straight through to get the vocabulary in order. The definitions are deliberately plain; the fuller treatment of most terms lives in their own articles on this site.

The core disciplines

SEO (Search Engine Optimization): The practice of improving a website so it ranks higher in traditional search results. Success is measured mainly by ranking position and clicks.

GEO (Generative Engine Optimization): The practice of making your business understood, trusted, and cited by generative AI engines such as ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google's AI Overviews. It is largely an entity and authority problem.

AEO (Answer Engine Optimization): The practice of structuring specific content so it can be extracted and delivered directly as the answer to a question, whether in an AI response, a voice assistant, or a featured snippet.

AI visibility: How often, and how accurately, AI engines mention or recommend your business when people ask relevant questions. It is the outcome that GEO and AEO work aims to improve.

Generative AI engine: An AI system that composes answers in natural language rather than only listing links. ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, and Claude are examples.

AI Overview: The AI-generated summary Google can show at the top of some search results, drawing on and citing web sources.

How AI engines work

LLM (large language model): The type of AI model behind most generative engines, trained on large amounts of text to predict and generate language.

Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG): A technique where an AI engine looks up current sources and uses them to build its answer, rather than relying only on what it learned in training. It is why fresh, well-structured pages can influence AI answers.

Hallucination: When an AI engine states something false or invented with confidence, such as a wrong address, service, or founding date for a business.

AI crawler: An automated program that fetches web pages for AI systems to learn from or retrieve. GPTBot, from OpenAI, is a well-known example. Whether you allow these crawlers affects what AI engines can see.

Entities and trust

Entity: A clearly identifiable real-world thing, such as a business, a person, or a place, that a machine can distinguish from similar things. AI engines recommend entities, not just pages.

Knowledge graph: A structured network of entities and the relationships between them. Search and AI systems use knowledge graphs to understand who and what a business is.

Knowledge panel: The information box Google can display for a recognized entity, summarizing key facts. Its presence signals that Google has a confident picture of the entity.

Wikidata: A free, structured, community-edited database of entities that many systems draw on as a reference. A well-formed entry can help machines identify a business unambiguously.

E-E-A-T: Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, and Trustworthiness — the quality signals search systems look for when judging whether a source deserves to be trusted.

Topical authority: The depth and breadth of your coverage of a subject, which signals that you are a reliable source on it rather than a one-off mention.

Technical building blocks

Structured data (schema markup): Code added to a page that labels its content in a standard, machine-readable format, such as a business's name, address, services, or FAQs.

FAQPage schema: A specific type of structured data that marks up question-and-answer pairs, making them easier for search and AI systems to extract.

robots.txt: A file at the root of a website that tells crawlers which areas they may or may not visit.

lms.txt: A proposed convention for a plain-text file that points AI systems to the most useful content on a site. It is an emerging idea, and support varies by engine.

Content and measurement

Direct-answer paragraph: The first one to three sentences under a question-style heading, written to fully answer the question on their own so an engine can lift them out.

Citation: A source an AI engine references or links when it composes an answer. Earning citations is a core goal of AI visibility work.

AI sentiment: The tone with which AI engines describe your business, such as positive, neutral, or negative, when they mention it.

Local pack: The map and short list of local businesses Google shows for location-based searches, heavily influenced by your Business Profile and reviews.

Review velocity: How quickly you are collecting new reviews. Recent, steady reviews are a trust signal for both local search and AI recommendations.

Branded vs. non-branded search: Branded searches include your business name; non-branded searches describe a need without naming you. Growth in non-branded search shows you are being discovered by people who did not already know you.

Where to go from here

If one term above is the one you keep tripping over, start with its dedicated article. If the whole list is new to you, the foundations — GEO, AEO, and entities — are the best place to begin, because the rest of the vocabulary builds on them.

Frequently Asked Questions

What is the difference between GEO and AEO?

GEO is about whether AI engines know, trust, and accurately represent your business overall — an entity and authority problem. AEO is about whether a specific piece of your content can be extracted and delivered as the direct answer to a specific question. The two reinforce each other.

What does AI visibility mean?

AI visibility is how often and how accurately AI engines such as ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google's AI Overviews mention or recommend your business when people ask relevant questions.

What is an entity in AI search?

An entity is a clearly identifiable real-world thing, such as a business, person, or place, that a machine can tell apart from similar things. AI engines recommend entities, so being clearly defined as one is foundational.

What is a citation in AI search?

A citation is a source an AI engine references or links when it composes an answer. Earning citations is a core goal of AI visibility work.

Do I need llms.txt?

llms.txt is an emerging, proposed convention for guiding AI systems to your best content, and support varies by engine. It is a low-cost addition, but it is not a substitute for clear structure, structured data, and strong content.

CONCLUSION

The vocabulary of AI visibility looks intimidating, but most of it reduces to a few ideas: be a clearly identifiable entity, publish content that answers questions directly, label it in a machine-readable way, and earn the trust signals that make an engine willing to cite you. Learn the terms above and the rest of the conversation gets much easier to follow.